who came near Vasagam's knowledge about rocketry was A Chandran, my college mate and later colleague who took over the mantle of Vikas group from me when I returned from Vernon in 1978.

Vasagam never haggled for power; in fact, he refused to even seek the recognition he richly deserved. I was convinced of this handicap—some call it a quality—when Sarabhai was in Trivandrum, sometime in the late 1960s, to see a thrust pick-up system. Vasagam had developed the system, but his boss S C Gupta, who headed the control and guidance group, was explaining the system and getting all the compliments from Sarabhai.

This was something I could not tolerate. Whenever someone had tried to take the entire credit for systems I had developed I had made sure that I got my pound of flesh. But this man, Vasagam, was such a *karma yogi* that he was happy with his boss taking all the pats on his back. At one point, when Sarabhai turned to me amidst the appreciation for the thrust pick-up, I said it was all Vasagam's sweat. Gupta was not amused.

Probably it was this soft nature of Vasagam that went against him when it came to the selection of ISRO chairman. Vasagam was moved out of ISRO and made the vice-chancellor of Anna University in Tamil Nadu. He silently took up the assignment and plunged headlong into academics with a smiling face.

Meanwhile V Sudhakar, a brilliant mechanical engineer, was brought into LPSC. My senior in Abdul Kalam's group, Sudhakar was passionate about his work, but his heart was more in setting up and heading KELTEC (Kerala Hightech Industries Limited). KELTEC, a Kerala government enterprise aimed at making high-precision parts for vital sectors, was actually a brainchild of ISRO to work around the US sanctions to get the cryogenic technology transferred from Russia. Sudhakar went on to head KELTEC, which became operational in 1994.

Muthunayagam, meanwhile, was clear that he would quit if he was not made the ISRO chairman. Muthunayagam as chairman was not an ideal situation for me, but I would any day vouch he is better qualified than Kasturirangan, who Rao finally picked for the job.